

Space agencies

Space agencies have been at the forefront of space exploration and technological innovation since the dawn of the space age in the 1950s. These government or internationally funded organizations set long-term goals, develop the equipment needed (often alongside commercial businesses), train astronauts, manage the missions, and encourage new ways of using space and space technology.

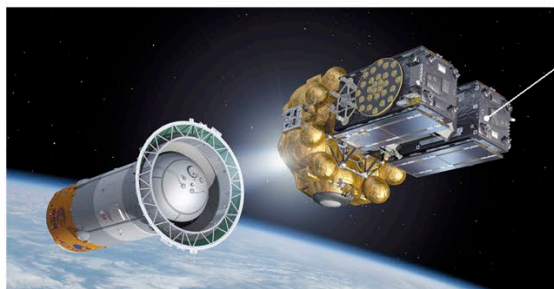


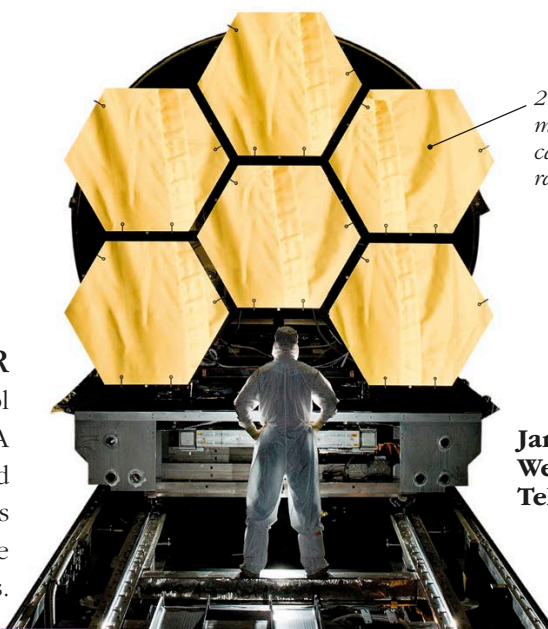
Illustration of ESA's two Galileo navigation satellites detaching from Soyuz upper stage in 2014

EUROPE'S SPACE AGENCY

The European Space Agency (ESA) was founded in 1975 from a merger of two earlier organizations. Its Ariane rocket series is now on its sixth generation, and the agency has launched increasingly ambitious space probes and satellites, as well as contributing to the International Space Station.

WORKING TOGETHER

Space agencies frequently collaborate to pool funding and expertise for major projects. ESA has contributed to the NASA-led Hubble and James Webb Space Telescopes, while Japan's JAXA and Russia's Roskosmos agencies are also frequent NASA partners.



21-ft (6.5-m) mirror designed to capture infrared radiation

James Webb Space Telescope

SPACE AGENCIES TIMELINE

1958

NASA is established in order to counter the Russian lead in satellite and space technology.

1959

NASA launches its first Pioneer space probes into near-Earth space. Throughout the 1960s, space probe missions become more ambitious.

1961

President John F. Kennedy (right) tasks NASA with landing a crewed mission on the moon, a goal which is achieved in July 1969.

